

STRAINS FROM THE PAST Ricky Kej with his three Grammy awards. *Break of Dawn* is nominated for a fourth

MUSIC

DIVINE SOUNDS

*Music composer **Ricky Kej** considers* Break of Dawn*– his new album based on Indian ragas that has been nominated for the Grammy Awards–his best work so far*

Ricky Kej has had a great 2024. He set a Guinness World Record when he conducted the "largest singing lesson", for 13,944 students of the Kalinga Institute of Social Sciences in Bhubaneswar; he taught the Indian national anthem. The three-time Grammy winner scored his fourth nomination for the awards, for his collection *Break of Dawn*, which is competing in the Best New Age, Ambient or Chant Album category. And he went on an "amazing trip" to Riyadh where he attended the 16th session of the Conference of the Parties (COP16) of the United Nations Convention to Combat Desertification (UNCCD), of which he is an official ambassador.

"Every year of my career has been better than the previous one," says the composer and environmental activist who calls *Break of Dawn* his "best work to date". The album, which comprises tracks based on nine different Indian classical ragas, is the first release on Vedam Records, a recently launched "wellness" sub-label by Universal Music. Kej says the set reflects his "belief in music as a transformative force for health and well-being".

"I love working on devotional music because it dives deep into the best parts of the musical form [a religion is] associated with, [whether it's] Hindustani classical, Western classical, or Sufi music." Similarly, he doesn't feel that timing 'Ram Ke Hriday Mein' a few days before the inauguration of the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya associates with him a political ideology. "In my mind, there's not much difference between nature and heritage," says Kej. "Creating a song about a temple, which is part of our ancient culture, is as good as creating a song about nature."

FOR AN ATHEIST, KEJ'S DISCOGRAPHY HAS PLENTY OF DEVOTIONAL MUSIC–LAST YEAR HE RELEASED TRACKS CONNECTED TO HINDUISM, ISLAM AND CHRISTIANITY

While Kej feels "there's not enough research" on the healing properties of music, he studied reports published by medical journal *The Lancet* to "figure out the kind of sounds the human ear appreciates [and] people all over the world feel can calm [them]", and drew inspiration from a Buddhist teaching that states "if the minds of living beings are impure, their land is also impure, but if their minds are pure, so is their land". Kej says "it's something that really resonated with me, even though I'm an atheist".

Yet, for an atheist, his discography has plenty of devotional music. He doesn't see this as contradictory. Last year, he released a track with qawwali troupe Warsi Brothers and songs dedicated to Lord Ram and Lord Shiva, and co-produced 'Sarvesa', a Sanskrit rendition of the Lord's Prayer, helmed by long-time collaborator, violinist Manoj George.

Environmental issues are a recurring theme in his work and, in 2025, in addition to a new "full-blown orchestral" album with Stewart Copeland, he will put out the scores for another natural history documentary (after 2019's National Award-winning *Wild Karnataka*) and the ecologically focused feature film *Papa Buka*. He will also develop albums for Vedam Records, but not before ensuring *Break of Dawn* gets due attention. "I'm going to do that till it's reached its proper potential because I've worked so hard creating it." ■

–Amit Gurbaxani

